

Day-1 Activity

Phishing Example

> How to Tell If a Link is Fake or Not

We've all received suspicious links at some point — maybe in a WhatsApp message, an email, or even a comment on social media. But how do you actually know if a link is safe before clicking it? Here's what to look for:

1. Look Closely at the Domain Name

This is the first thing to check. Scammers are clever — they create website addresses that *look* real but have tiny differences. For example:

- [arnazon.com](#) instead of [amazon.com](#)
- [paypal1.com](#) (that's the number 1, not the letter l)
- [apple-support-login.com](#) — real Apple would never have a domain like this

The trick is to slow down and actually *read* the URL carefully instead of just glancing at it.

2. HTTPS Doesn't Always Mean Safe

A lot of people think that if a link starts with [https://](#) and has a padlock icon, it's trustworthy. That's not entirely true. While HTTP sites are definitely risky, many fake sites also use HTTPS these days. So don't rely on the padlock alone — dig a little deeper.

3. Watch Out for Tricky Subdomains

This one confuses a lot of people. A link like [paypal.com.attacker.com](#) might *look* like it belongs to PayPal, but it doesn't. The actual domain is [attacker.com](#). A good habit is to read the URL from right to left before the first / — that tells you who really owns the page.

4. Be Careful with Shortened Links

Links like [bit.ly/xYz123](#) hide where they're actually taking you. Before clicking, paste them into a tool like [checkshorturl.com](#) or [unshorten.it](#) to see the real destination first.

5. Weird Characters or Super Long URLs

If a URL is unusually long, filled with random letters and numbers, or has things like %3A or %20 scattered through it — be cautious. These can be used to hide where the link is really going.

6. Check What File It's Trying to Download

If a link is pushing you to download something ending in .exe, .apk, .bat, or .zip and you weren't expecting it — that's a big red flag. Even unexpected PDFs or Word documents from strangers can be dangerous.

7. Does the Context Make Sense?

Ask yourself — does this link make sense right now? Got an "invoice" email but you didn't buy anything? A message saying "your account will be suspended" out of nowhere? These are pressure tactics scammers use to make you click without thinking.

8. Raw IP Address in the Link

If a link looks like http://192.168.1.1/login instead of a proper website name, that's suspicious. Genuine websites rarely send you to a raw IP address.

Tools You Can Use to Check a Link (Without Even Clicking It)

Tool	What It Does
VirusTotal (virustotal.com)	Checks the link against 70+ security engines
Google Safe Browsing	Tells you if Google has flagged it
URLVoid	Checks the site's reputation
Whois Lookup	Shows when the domain was registered — very new ones are suspicious
Web of Trust (WOT)	Shows community trust ratings

A Simple Rule to Remember

Before clicking any link, just ask yourself three quick questions:

Was I expecting this link? Does the web address look exactly right? Is someone trying to rush or scare me into clicking?

If something feels off — trust that feeling. Instead of clicking the link, just open your browser and type the website address yourself. It takes five extra seconds and could save you a lot of trouble.